

Chapter 58: 丑陋 (Ugly)

Hearing her question, Qiu Yi looked surprised but immediately answered: "Naturally you look beautiful. In this disciple's heart, Master's appearance is unrivaled, let alone in this mortal realm."

As the Divine Venerable, Chu Qingqiu had never cared about appearances. Sometimes she wouldn't even wear a single ornament on her head. Why was she asking about her looks today? Qiu Yi scratched the back of her head, extremely puzzled.

However, her words didn't seem to convince Chu Qingqiu, who still stared at her reflection in the mirror for a long time without moving.

After all, Qiu Yi had always obeyed her every command—how could she say she didn't look good? Besides, even if Qiu Yi truly thought she looked good, even if everyone in the world thought she looked good, different people could have completely opposite preferences. It was normal that Ning Fuyi didn't find her attractive.

Thinking this, Chu Qingqiu suddenly felt a wave of shock. What was she thinking? She was actually starting to worry about Ning Fuyi's preferences! How absurd.

She waved her hand to turn the bronze mirror around, then pulled out something like transparent silk from her sleeve. She gently placed it on her face, and her appearance changed. Her originally outstanding peach blossom eyes and dark brows with cherry lips all became duller. Combined with mortal clothing and makeup, even Qiu Yi couldn't recognize her.

"Ning Fuyi." She called out. Ning Fuyi, who was still talking with Liu Wenzhu, responded and walked over. Chu Qingqiu gave her another piece of silk. Ning Fuyi's appearance also changed—she lost some of her ghostly aura and became much more gentle and beautiful.

"You and I often travel in the jianghu¹ and have seen many people. We might inevitably be recognized. It's better to use disguises. This is Thousand Change Brocade, a transformation artifact that isn't affected by barriers."

Chu Qingqiu then looked at the expectant Qiu Yi. Her words turned on her lips before she finally said, "As for Qiu Yi, you've rarely left the mountain gate, so you don't need to change."

Hearing this, Qiu Yi became so excited that her hair flew up. She clenched her hands together: "Master is finally willing to take me along to eliminate demons?"

"What you said does make sense. As my disciple, Chu Qingqiu, you can't always stay cloistered in cultivation." Chu Qingqiu's tone became more severe.

"But remember, you must not act rashly. If that female emperor is a demon, exposing yourself would be suicide. If she's not a demon, then we would be disrupting mortal order and inevitably violate immortal laws. When divine tribulation comes, even your master cannot save you."

"If you disobey even slightly, don't ever think about stepping out of the mountain gate again."

Although Qiu Yi was somewhat frightened by her tone, the joy of finally being useful prevailed, so she nodded repeatedly.

Liu Wenzhu at the side looked at the three of them and carefully spoke: "Divine Venerable, what about me?"

"You're familiar with Qi Kingdom, and this is Liu family territory. You staying outside for support would be better than us. Once we enter the imperial palace, if we discover anything wrong, we'll find a way to notify you. Then you can return to the mountain gate to tell Elder Pingyao, or borrow some manpower from the Liu family to assist." Chu Qingqiu looked at her.

Liu Wenzhu's pale face flushed red, her expression timid: "Just me alone outside? Such a big matter, I..."

"You should often hear your father Liu Wenhai's words." Chu Qingqiu's voice carried no preaching intent, just speaking plainly. "Since you want to compete for the position of family head in the future, this training is necessary."

Liu Wenzhu took a deep breath. Although still fearful inside, she gritted her teeth and nodded: "This disciple understands."

"Master, didn't you say that barrier would suppress immortal power? We can't hide our auras. If that female emperor really is from the demon race, wouldn't she see through us at a glance?" Qiu Yi asked again.

Chu Qingqiu flipped her wrist, and three white pills appeared in her palm. She handed them to her and Ning Fuyi: "Take these before entering the palace. As long as it hasn't been seven days, even a True God² wouldn't be able to detect your identity."

"Besides, it also has the effect of connecting minds. After taking them simultaneously, you can hear each other's thoughts, but you only need to concentrate on what you want to say for it to work."

"However, this medicine is precious. I only have three pills, so we must hurry." Chu Qingqiu said.

"Divine Venerable's sleeve is like a cosmic pouch—how do you have everything?" Ning Fuyi reached to touch her sleeve but was slapped on the back of her hand by Chu Qingqiu and pushed away.

Not only was Ning Fuyi not angry, she smiled while rubbing her hand, feeling grateful that Chu Qingqiu had come along, saving her much trouble.

If she had gone alone, it wasn't that she had no way to sneak in, but those methods were somewhat disreputable, incomparable to Chu Qingqiu who had treasures all over her body.

"Since that's the case, let's not waste time." Chu Qingqiu said and took the lead toward the imperial palace.

The innermost part of the capital was the imperial city. After approaching the imperial city, carriages and horses on the road visibly became much sparser, but the brick buildings became much more magnificent. Glazed tiles reflected the sunset's radiance like layers of gold.

The three were stopped outside the imperial city by roadside guards. A tall guard in armor stepped forward and shouted: "Who goes there?"

Chu Qingqiu didn't speak but raised the imperial proclamation in her hand. Several guards exchanged glances and looked suspiciously at the three. After seeing their appearances clearly, their attitude immediately became enthusiastic.

Since the female emperor's personality changed drastically, all the good-looking young men and women in the capital had been sent to the palace. The female emperor was also picky—those who didn't catch her eye were all driven out. Over time, no more beautiful people could be found.

Now they didn't know what stroke of luck this was—not only had beautiful girls come, but three at once! If they brought them before the female emperor, who knew how much reward they'd get!

"What are the three ladies' names? Where are you from? Where are your household registrations? Are you from Qi Kingdom?" one guard bent over and asked, only to be pushed by another guard beside him: "Why ask so much? His Majesty doesn't even care. Just bring them in, make up the numbers, and we'll get our reward money!"

"True." The pushed guard nodded repeatedly and smiled ingratiatingly: "Ladies, follow me. I'll take you into the palace right away."

Ning Fuyi took a deep breath, put on a dignified appearance, lifted her steps to sway her gauze skirt, and followed him toward the imperial palace.

Passing through the spacious broad bluestone streets, the main gate of the imperial palace came into view. The enormous arched gate, one zhang³ high, was painted with gold lacquer, brilliant and dazzling in the sunset. The palace walls towered into the clouds—looking up made one's neck slightly sore.

The guard who brought them said something to the palace guards at the gate, and the palace doors slowly opened.

Chu Qingqiu was the first to step through the palace gate. Her expression didn't change, as if the barrier had no effect on her, so Ning Fuyi and Qiu Yi followed her forward.

As soon as they crossed the threshold, both their faces turned pale simultaneously, their steps immediately becoming unsteady. However, Ning Fuyi quickly adapted to the powerless feeling of having her immortal power rapidly drained and walked normally.

Qiu Yi, having less training after all, nearly fell to her knees as her legs went weak. Ning Fuyi quickly supported her from the side, preventing her from being exposed right at the palace gate.

Qiu Yi steadied her steps with lingering fear, pulled her elbow from Ning Fuyi's hand, moved her mouth, and still stiffly said thanks.

Ning Fuyi moved her mouth in response.

The mortal realm's imperial palace was different from the immortal realm's pavilions. It wasn't as flashy and gorgeous as Zhaoyao Mountain, but was more solemn and dignified. Towering high walls divided the palace gardens into squares and corridors, with palace servants occasionally walking past in formation.

The three walked for a long time before being brought to a palace hall. Outside the hall already stood more than ten young men and women—all absolutely beautiful at first glance. Except for a few who seemed relatively calm, the rest all looked mournful, and several women were already wiping tears with handkerchiefs.

"What's all the crying for? Being selected into the palace by His Majesty is your good fortune. If you can serve His Majesty well, you'll be second only to one and above ten thousand⁴ in the future. Why worry about food, clothing, and shelter!" An elderly palace servant led several young palace servants over, speaking harshly.

"Still crying! Be careful not to dirty His Majesty's eyes, or we'll throw you in the lotus pond to feed the fish!" The palace servant glared at a beautiful young man whose eyes were red from crying, frightening him into quickly covering his mouth with only whimpering remaining.

"Scaring people like this, who knows how ugly this female emperor must be." Ning Fuyi concentrated her thoughts.

Chu Qingqiu must have heard her words, because she glanced at her with her peripheral vision but didn't speak.

"Men and women separate into proper lines. His Majesty will arrive soon. Perform well—if you show disrespect before the throne, don't blame me for being impolite." The palace servant announced loudly, then clapped forcefully: "Hurry up!"

Under her scolding, everyone began to slowly move, forming two orderly lines.

It was already late, but not too dark. The setting sun's afterglow dyed half the sky orange-yellow. Ning Fuyi and the other two stood at the very end of the formation, waiting quietly.

After about another incense stick's worth of time, someone suddenly shouted: "Greet His Majesty!"

At the same time, the doors of the great hall before them opened in response. First came a strange fragrance, like the most mellow incense aged for thousands of years, quietly spreading around them. The young men and women who had been crying earlier now all stopped their sniffing to smell that fragrance.

Then a pair of delicate feet appeared in everyone's lowered gaze, wearing flowing cloud boots⁵, with layers of crimson skirt hem dragging with her steps, covering those feet.

Looking up, her waist was tightly bound by a red cord woven with gold thread. Further up was a curvaceous figure, shoulders topped with heavily embroidered cloud shoulders⁶. The magnificent wide robes and large sleeves hanging on this tall body didn't look bulky at all.

"Raise your heads." The female emperor spoke, her voice melodious and magnetic.

Only then did everyone timidly raise their heads. When they saw the female emperor's appearance clearly, there was a chorus of gasps.

No one in the markets dared discuss the emperor's appearance, so no one knew that the rumored debauched and immoral female emperor actually had such beautiful looks—narrow, alluring eyes, brows light as distant mountains, red lips like pearls.

Not very dignified, but with endless charm, quite fitting with her debauched and immoral nature.

Ning Fuyi stared at her face, and Chu Qingqiu's indifferent voice suddenly sounded in her mind: "Does this kind of appearance look good?"

Ning Fuyi didn't understand why Chu Qingqiu was asking this, so her mind honestly answered: "I never expected such extraordinary beauty."

Chu Qingqiu didn't know why she had asked, and felt a bit angry after asking. Her gaze swept over the female emperor and then coldly looked away.

"I still can't detect any demonic energy." Qiu Yi's voice sounded.

"Not detecting demonic energy has two possibilities—either this person is just a debauched and immoral emperor, or she's an extremely powerful demon. Otherwise, how could that barrier be explained?" Ning Fuyi said, then asked Chu Qingqiu: "Divine Venerable, can you still use immortal power?"

"Some has been absorbed, but it's still manageable."

Ning Fuyi roughly sensed that although most of her internal power was gone, it wasn't completely depleted. Although she couldn't use it for now to avoid exposing her identity, there was still some security.

However, Qiu Yi's bitter voice sounded in her mind: "But Master, I don't have even half a bit of immortal power left!"

Chu Qingqiu's profile tensed for a moment, as if helpless.

While the three were conversing in their minds, the female emperor had already slowly walked past each person with a group of palace servants following. Those fingers painted with rouge touched each person's face one by one, then moved away in disgust.

"I have no one to attend my bed tonight. You've been selecting for so many days and picked such goods—do you want to be beaten with boards again?" Her vermillion lips curved slightly as she spoke quietly.

This statement scared the palace servants behind her to tremble like sieves, hastily bowing and scraping: "Your Majesty, don't worry! There are still a few more back there, all good-looking!"

The female emperor's gaze flowed, looking them over until she made them all break out in sweat, before continuing to move back. As she walked closer, that strange fragrance became even stronger.

Seeing her approach Chu Qingqiu's side, Ning Fuyi couldn't help but clench her sleeves, her phoenix eyes lowering.

Actually, honestly speaking, Chu Qingqiu was indeed the most suitable person to approach the female emperor. But for some reason, the thought of Chu Qingqiu being taken notice of made deep resentment grow in her heart.

"Your Majesty, look at this one—gorgeous as peach blossoms, the most handsome among those entering the palace!" The elderly palace servant suddenly pulled Chu Qingqiu forward toward the female emperor, pushing her slender body into a stumble. Ning Fuyi's resentment immediately surged as she reached out to steady her.

She was already prepared to be questioned, but the female emperor paid no attention to her actions and instead frowned and stepped back to avoid them.

"Such an ugly person dares to be brought before me—you truly are tired of living." She said coldly, then saw something that made a smile leap to her lips.

"I think this girl is not bad." Her bright red fingertip pointed lightly at Qiu Yi, who was standing at the very end of the formation, still trying to pull back her master!

Footnotes:

1. **江湖 (jianghu)** - The martial arts world; the realm of wandering warriors, outlaws, and adventures.
2. **真神 (True God)** - One of the highest cultivation realms mentioned in the story's power system.
3. **丈 (zhang)** - A traditional Chinese unit of measurement, approximately 3.33 meters or 11 feet.
4. **一人之下万人之上** - A classical Chinese phrase meaning "second only to one person (the emperor) and above ten thousand others," indicating extremely high status.
5. **流云靴 (flowing cloud boots)** - Ornate footwear with decorative cloud patterns.
6. **云肩 (cloud shoulders)** - Decorative shoulder pieces or shawls worn over robes, often embroidered with cloud motifs.